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Facing the New World Order: Middle East Geopolitics and Palestinian Peace Strategies

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ABSTRACT: The purpose of this paper is to examine the future geopolitics of the Middle East against the backdrop of the Gulf War crisis and its aftermath. Special attention was given to the case of Palestinians and their search for peaceful solution to their territorial conflict with Israel. It is suggested that in an era of a new world order most Middle Eastern governments will give priority to their domestic problems, gearing toward power sharing at home and evolving a certain degree of liberalizations as an attempt to be accommodated within a worldwide sphere of social, economic and political reconciliation. Having overcome the post-Gulf political isolation, the Palestinians are now in a better position to make their claim for self-determination recognized. Ultimately, the fulfilment of such claim is desirable for achieving lasting peace and regional stability. This paper also proposes concrete suggestions for future Palestinian territorial behaviour addressed mainly to the Palestinian government to be considered while they are engaging in peaceful negotiations with Israel.

Introduction

At a time when democracy and liberalization have swept the globe from South Africa to the former Soviet Union and its satellite socialist bloc, the Middle East with its Arab core has not been immune to change. Similar trends have been underway in most polities in the region (Hudson 1991), with important implications for both interstate and international world relationships. The recent Gulf crisis highlighted these trends, and cannot be regarded as a purely local or regional event. It should provide a “testing ground for the rapprochement between East and West as applied to north-south relations” (Sid-Ahmed 1991, 16).

Iraq’s August 1990 invasion of Kuwait and widespread indignation in the West over Saddam Hussein should not be allowed to block perception of ongoing subtrends. Nor should the rise of Islamic forces (Sharabi 1988) necessarily be viewed as a retreat from pluralism or a reactionary shift incompatible with democracy (Salame’ 1993). Political reforms today are on the agenda of many key Arab states (The Editors 1992, 3). Some authors may regard these reforms as a tactic to cope with economic and social crises, such as the reforms that followed political unrest in Algeria, Egypt, Jordan, Morocco, Sudan, and Tunisia (Esposito and Piscatori 1991, 429; Amawi 1992, 26-29).

Orientalist stereotyping (Hudson 1991, 407; Sidaway 1994) and traditional disengagement from the Middle East, the Arab world and Arab civilization (Said 1991, 15; Crystal 1994, 262) are likely to be salient factors impinging on the consciousness of Western observers, causing them to underestimate or misread contemporary changes in the Middle East. Gudrun Krämer (1992) pointed to a similar notion of stereotyping in the treatment of both Islamic and Arab issues: “The more sophisticated skeptics usually refer to Islam as an effective barrier against development, modernity and democracy; the less-sophisticated to the Arab mind, which is allegedly inclined towards authoritarianism and incapable of accepting pluralism and self-critique” (Krämer 1992, 23).

The aim of this essay is to explore the future geopolitics of the Middle East against the backdrop of the Gulf War crisis and its aftermath¹⁾. The projected year 2000 was chosen as a reference point to project a set of short-term changes. Discussion of Palestinian discourse attempts to develop a distinctively Palestinian perspective on the issues. My approach is analogous to that adopted by geographers such as Saul B. Cohen (1992a), who explores geopolitical issues with an express aim: to influence policy and its makers, to venture into the little plowed terrain of applied political geography. In his own words: “My experience and bias is that of an American geographer. My

prescriptions for the years ahead are directed, therefore, to the American policy-makers. It is time for geographers to speak out." (p. 14). Elsewhere, Cohen's analysis (1986, 1992b) was clearly constructed with an argument to justify and advance Israeli interests (at least as perceived from the vantage of the Israeli Labour Party). Like many Israeli commentators, or those with pronounced Zionist leanings (Barzilai and Peleg 1994; Karsh 1994; Perlmutter 1995), Cohen fails to grasp and concede that the territories conquered by Israel since June 1967 are in fact occupied areas, seized by force, and that they should be returned to their previous peoples and states in accordance with international laws and several UN resolutions. All my own specific proposals outlined below are compatible with existing UN resolutions; they are thus underpinned by a framework of international legitimacy and consensus, though conceptualized and articulated from a Palestinian vantage and scholarly prism.

Pan-Arabism, Islamism and the State

A vast and controversial literature exists on pan-Arabism, Islamism, the state and the dialectical interrelationships between them. While these issues are beyond the scope of the present discussion²⁾, there is no doubt that both pan-Arabism and Islamism have weakened the development of a strong state in the Arab world in various periods. Thus, the citizen's loyalty was not restricted to the immediate territorial unit and its polity, but also transcended the formal borders of the state (cf. Brynen and Noble 1991, 130-131). A mode of transnational allegiance has shaped (geo)political identities in the Arab world in distinctive ways, rendering state boundaries less salient. According to Brown (1984), the Arab peoples did not develop a strong state for reasons anchored in Islamic political thought and the genesis of an intermediary bureaucracy. "The critical underlying point is that Islamic society permitted individuals to deal directly with their leaders, whereas Western societies gradually interposed a layer of institutions between ruler and ruled" (Brown 1984, 28). Much analysis demonstrates a basic accommodation between pan-Arabism and Islam (Chalala 1987, 32-42). Sa'ad Eddin Ibrahim (1987) has pointed out a certain overlap between Islamic universalism and pan-Arabism; one need not preclude the other. Islam has, in his view, possibly acted as an aggregating and integrating force—ultimately even fostering pan-Arabism (Ibrahim 1987, 61-64). Ghassan Salamé (1988) explained Iranian attacks against Arab nationalism in terms of the discourse of authenticity. In their insistence on unity and "authenticity" in their opposition to foreign influence in the region, many Arab Sunni Islamists do not necessarily view their ideology as a negation of pan-Arabism, but rather as a more radical, ie, more "authentic" nationalism (Salamé 1988, 352).

There is general agreement among scholars that if the 1950s/1960s were dominated by Arab nationalism and socialism, the 1970s and 1980s witnessed the rise of

"Islamic fundamentalism." As Hisham Sharabi (1988) has noted, "Islamic fundamentalism expresses mass sentiment and belief as no nationalist or socialist ideology has been able to do up until now" (Sharabi 1988, 136). With the death of Gamal abd al-Nasir, Egyptian president and charismatic Arab leader, in 1970, pan-Arabism faced a severe crisis. A new political order associated both with oil power and the diffusion of power emerged (Salamé 1988, 347). In 1978, Fouad 'Ajami went so far as to proclaim the death of pan-Arabism ('Ajami 1978, 365-373), and his thesis gained considerable support from Western scholars (eg Brown 1984). However, numerous Arab intellectuals disagree with him (Chalala 1987, 47) – such as Hassan Nafaa', who argues that 'Ajami confuses "the idea and its implementation, the ideology and the political movement. The idea of 'one nation with an immortal mission' has never been translated into a viable political project. It is still a slogan, like that of the Communist Manifesto: Workers of the world unite! To say that pan-Arabism has died because it failed to achieve the one Arab nation is like saying Marxism does not exist anymore because it failed to unify the workers of the world!" (Nafaa' 1983, 173-174, 182).

The 'Ajami-Nafaa' debate provides an important perspective for the definition of the state. In 'Ajami's thesis, a logical shift of power has replaced the pan-Arabist system by a state-system; the boundaries of Arab states are no longer "illusory and permeable," and "irreversible changes have already taken place to make interstate boundaries harder and more legitimate" ('Ajami 1978, 365). Salamé arrived at a similar notion of particularism and the "rediscovery of the Arab idea" (Salamé 1988, 350-352). Commenting on 'Ajami's argument that the logic of the state has replaced pan-Arabist conceptions, Nafaa' says the following: "In such conditions, a workable pan-Arab system of states' based on the concept of *raison d'état* is hardly conceivable. Because in the states where institutions are dead and the mechanism process of consensus formation is blocked, the *raison d'état* may be the *raison de la famille royale* or that of a dictator. Such a system will constantly be under the pressure of centrifugal forces which are unable to express themselves through adequate legitimate channels; and, after his emergence, a powerful Arab leader could be tempted to manipulate them" (Nafaa' 1983, 196).

Major changes have occurred in the Arab world and in the Middle East since the "Ajami-Nafaa' debate almost a decade ago. Yet, Iraq's August 1990 invasion of Kuwait served to sharpen the debates of the previous decade. Before August 2, 1990, the Arab world appeared to be politically disintegrating, especially when Egypt became isolated following its peace treaty with Israel. Syria and Iraq were locked in continuous conflict. Syria backed Iran in its war against Iraq, morally and perhaps in other ways. Saudi Arabia and the Gulf states formed the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) as a reaction against the thrust and attraction of the Iranian Islamic revolution. Israel invaded Lebanon in 1982 as the country was ravaged by civil war. None of these developments contradicted 'Ajami's thesis

of the emergence of a single-state system, even though they likewise did not necessarily point to the end of pan-Arabism. The emphasis now was on internal local state issues rather than the old dogma of the “superior interests of the Arab nation.” Individual states now had a better vision of their interest and role in the region. Particularism increased, and a high level of political cultural identity among individual Arab states became manifest.

Regardless of the nature of regime in a given state, civilians identified themselves with their immediate territorial unit. From this perspective, the concept of *raison d'état* was redefined and gained new salience. In such a situation, it can be expected that state-society relationships will be altered; more citizens will participate in state institution building. More important is the emergence of middle class influence in various spheres, forcing traditional leaders to accommodate. Arab leaders in Algeria, Tunisia, Egypt, Jordan, and Syria experienced these changes on the part of their population and successfully introduced a degree of democratization and liberalization (Hudson 1991; Abed 1991, 32). In short, changes of this nature were accompanied by the crystallization of the concept of “state” in the Arab world, itself the result of a long process. This concept, internalized in the Arab population, became highly beneficial for their existence and identity.

The Middle East and the New World Order

In August 1990, Saddam Hussein confronted the Islamic and Arab worlds with two dilemmas that deeply affected their mass population and intelligentsia. First, Iraq's invasion of Kuwait was aimed at obliterating a sovereign Arab country, thus violating the sacred goal of self-determination that all Arabs had struggled to “earn” throughout a long decolonization process (El-Orabi 1991). Although inter-Arab states divisions and conflicts occasionally erupted and left visible scars on the Arab body politic, in “no previous case had the entire *raison d'être* of an Arab state been challenged and then rudely obliterated by another” (Abed 1991, 31). The invasion in effect not only “wrest[ed] the right of self-determination of Kuwait from those to whom it naturally belongs—the people of Kuwait” (Khalidi 1991, 13), but also undermined the remarkable achievement that had just crystallized in the mind of the Arab people, namely the focus on the state as a viable locus for development freed of the burden of pan-Arabism. As a consequence, Saddam was not supported in his invasion of Kuwait.

The second dilemma was associated with the spillover effect of the invasion and the US-led response as it related to the long history of foreign interference in the region, especially efforts to exploit and control oil. Because of such interference, the main feature of the Arab socioeconomic status quo was the incongruence between the geography of wealth and population distribution. Such distributive injustice is shown by the following: “8 percent of the 200 million Arabs who lived in the oil countries owned more than 50 percent of the aggregate

gross national product of the Arab world and . . . the per capita income with the native population of the oil countries ranged between \$15,000 and \$20,000, while that of the vast majority of the 200 million Arabs was below \$1,000” (Khalidi 1991, 19).

In his appeals to the Arab and Muslim masses (outside the oil-producing countries) to support Iraq against US-led forces, Saddam managed to convey a clear message calling for a new Arab order, and a dismantling of the existing socioeconomic status quo. He accused the Saudis and the Kuwaitis of injustice and of inviting in foreign troops to perpetuate this status quo. In this regard, Saddam gained considerable popular support. Even before the war erupted, there were mass demonstrations in the *Mashriq* and *Maghrib* countries calling for the immediate withdrawal of foreign troops from the Arabian peninsula. Nationalist and Islamist forces spontaneously coalesced in the streets of many Arab capitals. This suggests that a “latent power” within the masses exists, and it is conceivable that this power will take the form of pan-Arabism interlinked with Islamism, a powerful wedge to confront western and foreign domination. The future political map of the Middle East will be shaped by two political realities: the degree to which the United States translates its current military presence into permanent bases in the region, and the reaction of nationalist and Islamic voices in the Arab countries. These two voices are likely to be unified against the American presence if it becomes permanent. In such a situation, Saddam's accusations against the West will fuel the national forces, while the Islamic movement will see “a new crusade led by the world's great super power, coming to gobble up our oil resources, humiliate our people and so forth” (Quandt 1990-91, 12). It is likely that the US military arsenal will remain in the Gulf area and in Arabia in particular at least to the end of the present century, if not beyond. The two immediate underlying factors here are (1) Saddam's having remained in power in Iraq and (2) the war's relative strengthening of Iran's position, and Iran's Islamic activism in the region—two elements perceived by the West as a source of instability (cf. Eilts 1994). However, there might be a simpler, more logical reason for the continuing presence of the US army in Arabia: that America has acquired a levered political position in the region, and will remain there to preserve it. Even more understandable is the transfer of American military arsenal from Germany to Arabia as a part of a new strategic distribution of American forces around the globe.

Assuming that the US army will remain in Arabia as a form of neo-colonialism, what can we project as a possible configuration for the geopolitics of the Middle East in the year 2000? First, some territorial definitions are in order. For the purpose of this discussion, the term Middle East comprises the Levant countries, the Arabian peninsula countries, as well as Iran and Egypt. Libya and Sudan, located on the periphery, are excluded. The two non-Arab countries belonging geographically to the Middle East – Cyprus and Turkey – are likely to be more European-oriented in their future development, and have also been excluded from the present survey.

Towards the Year 2000

In the aftermath of the Gulf War, most Middle Eastern countries will continue to live in a post-Gulf war atmosphere for several years. The continuing sanctions on Iraq, banning her from selling oil, coupled with antagonistic western media toward Saddam Hussein (Wilcken 1995), serve only to enhance such an atmosphere. At the same time, internal forces will continue to pressure leaders of states to respond positively to democracy and liberalization. Islamic forces will reinforce their positions and influence in countries where the economic situation is most uncertain.

The Palestinian-Israeli conflict, recently in a new phase following the mutual recognition between Israel and the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), is unlikely to have a major impact on the interstate Arab relationships or the internal processes of liberalization in a given state. It may, however, help to (re)shape a new set of relationships between the Palestinians and the Arab polities.

Arab countries have been forced to set new priorities in the wake of the war. Support of the Palestinian struggle for statehood now is of relatively low priority. Those Arab states who opposed Saddam Hussein and joined the US-led coalition are likely to push for the peaceful solution of the Palestinian problem, at least to justify to their people their decision to join the Western coalition against a fellow-Arab country. But this enthusiasm will probably wane after some time due to their inability to influence United States foreign policy or reduce US support for Israel.

A short review of priorities for the major countries of the region can provide a useful indication of emerging domestic orientations. Starting with the Gulf states, Kuwait's number-one priority is rebuilding the country. Estimates of the cost for rebuilding range from \$60 billion upwards. Kuwait earned no oil revenues during the period of Iraqi invasion, and Iraqi troops dynamited 60–85% of its wells before they withdrew. It may take 5–10 years to restore the emirate's oil production to pre-war levels (Sadowski 1991, 7). This situation has a direct impact on the flow of capital from wealthy Arab oil states to non-oil countries. Kuwait will not be in a position to contribute significantly to the poorest states. What is probably more fundamental are the new emerging patterns of labour migration. The war resulted in permanent or temporary displacement of an estimated 5 million people from more than 30 countries (New York Times, 16 June 1991). Kuwait and the rest of the Gulf countries (Qatar, Bahrain and United Arab Emirates) will likely restrict future labour migration from Arab countries and give preference to workers from the South Asian countries who neither speak Arabic nor care about the political affairs of the host countries. A recent study by Al-Sabah and El-Shalakani (1994) on post-war labour migration to Kuwait nevertheless reveals that such restrictions apparently do not affect the Egyptian workers (Al-Sabah and El-Shalakani 1994, 78), whose country was an ardent supporter of Kuwait. Another study conducted by Russell and Al-

Ramadhan (1994) clearly concluded that Kuwait's post-war migration policy been marked "kuwaitization of the country," including resolutions for limiting non-Kuwaiti employment in government institutions. The authors note that the "most significant [aspect of such migration policy] is the open declaration that sources of the expatriate population will be diversified and nationality and ethnicity will be considered when admitting migrants" (Russell and Al-Ramadhan 1994, 584). Contextually, migration policy measures in Kuwait are taken to safeguard the country's special distinctiveness and cultural identity. At the same time, the rate of workers' remittances from the Gulf states will decrease correspondingly, and this will add to the burden of the non-oil-producing countries. Kuwait's dispute with Iraq over boundaries remains unresolved (Karam 1994). Kuwait will have to provide its monetary share of any future security arrangement for the Gulf. Some authors are optimistic about the emergence of a new Kuwaiti society that will "most likely be uncompromising in seeking a new role in determining their destiny within the context of the [Kuwaiti] 1962 constitution" (Ghabra 1991, 214).

Iraq has been economically devastated by the war. Allied air strikes rapidly demolished much of its economic infrastructure: bridges, power plants, factories and refineries. On August 2, 1990, Iraq was already shouldering a \$23 billion fiscal deficit and \$80 billion in foreign debts (Sadowski 1991, 7). Post-war reconstruction in Iraq has been estimated roughly at \$100–200 billion (Brynen and Noble 1991, 137, note 19). Iraq's main priorities towards the end of the present century are to build the country and to rebuild its army. Reflecting on Iraq's pre-war might, the UN nuclear weapons inspector dispatched to Iraq, David Kay (1995), testified that his team and those who monitor proliferation "were surprised by the magnitude and advanced state of Iraq's efforts to obtain nuclear explosive devices" (p. 85). He further contended that the nuclear program alone involved investment amounting to \$10 billion (Kay 1995, 85). The Iraqis will try to avoid any military confrontation with the United States. They will try to sell its oil for a good price to compensate for the loss. Pre-war Iraqi revenue from oil sales stood at \$18 billion annually. At the same time, much effort will be given to suppress internal dissent (eg Kurds and Shi'ite Muslims) (Garrity 1993; Bhattacharya 1994). Iraq will also seek to establish good neighbourly relationships with Iran, a new important regional power emerging following the war and a potential ally for Iraq against an American presence in Arabia.

Iran as a new political power will lead the Islamic forces, and will likely play an important role in determining the fate of some Arab regimes. At the same time, Iran will devote much effort to building its technological capability, improving its diplomatic relationships with European countries, and probably with East Asia (Japan, China) (El Shafei 1991). Iran is still the fourth largest holder of world crude oil reserves, commanding 9.2% of the total. It is also the second largest owner of natural gas reserves, with

14.6% of the world total (McLachlan 1995, 53). McLachlan (1995) describes Iran's 1994-99 projected Five-Year Plan as "designed to justify economic growth within a defensive economic strategy" (p.53).

After the war, Saudi Arabia gained new international respect and self-confidence at home. The Saudi kingdom successfully managed to handle both the Gulf crisis and the logistical demands of well over a million foreign troops and Kuwaiti refugees on its soil. Saudi Arabia emerged from the war relatively unscathed. Although the Saudis invited the foreign troops, they bore the major cost of the war. According to Yahya Sadowski (1991), "By August 1991, Saudi Arabia will have spent some \$64 billion on war and associated costs, and some well-placed Saudis estimate the sum may actually reach as high as \$80 billion" (Sadowski 1991, 6). A substantial portion of this cost should be recovered through extra oil production and the rise of oil prices during the crisis. The Saudis had to increase their oil production from 5.6 million barrels per day (bpd) to 8.7 million in order to meet global market demands. At the same time, the price of oil increased from \$15 per barrel to over \$20 during the crisis. With possession of more than 25% of the world's oil reserves, and the fifth largest reserves of natural gas (Drysdale; Blake 1985; International Herald Tribune, 11 December 1991, 16), Saudi Arabia will likely overcome the current war expenses in a short period. Saudi Arabia remains the only viable source of wealth to provide monetary aid to non-oil-producing Arab countries, although its primary efforts will probably go towards building its military capability and increasing its influence in the Gulf. The Saudi rulers, who have accumulated both power and tremendous wealth, feel most vulnerable to any external ideas, particularly new ideologies from Iran. Faksh and Faris (1993) note that in order to "preserve the regional status quo against forces of nationalism and radicalism, and thereby ensure regime survival and continuity" (p. 278), the Saudis adopted a foreign policy marked by compromise and consensus in which 'dollar diplomacy'-riyal diplomacy' has been the hallmark of such policy (Faksh and Faris 1993, 278).

Among the non-oil-rich countries of the region, Egypt and Syria joined the US-led coalition against Iraq and were rewarded, gaining some relief from the economic woes that had plagued them in the 1980s. Jordan, Yemen, Sudan, and the Palestinians – which the Saudis felt had shown too much sympathy for Iraq – are faced with enormous economic problems. Since the flow of monetary aid from the oil-rich states will dramatically drop, these countries will desperately have to acquire some aid from Western countries, particularly the United States. These countries can allow a certain democratization to move forward, and show a keen interest in resolving the Palestinian Israeli conflict peacefully. In doing so, they might become credible as potential recipients of Western support, and be brought into the sphere of US and European Union interest.

In summing up this period, the Middle East by the year 2000 will be much poorer than it was in 1992. Inequalities between Arab oil-rich and non-oil-producing states are likely to

become even more pronounced. General trends of expected political and economic transformation in many key Middle Eastern countries have been sketched. These trends alone do not account for complexity of the political map of the Middle East. Various unpredictable developments inside and outside the region could generate a solution to the Palestinian-Israeli conflict. An earlier draft of this paper (Falah 1992; see also Falah 1993, 248) also suggested such a rapprochement on the horizon as a possible scenario. At that time, few could foresee that Israel and the PLO would recognize one another two years later.

The 1992 Israeli election did in fact bring the Labour party to power, replacing the right-wing *Likud* party (under Shamir's leadership). The Likud was not prepared to accept any form of peace with the Palestinians which eventually could lead to a withdrawal from any territories occupied by Israel in the June 1967 War (Khalidi 1992; Shlaim 1994a). The Labour party, whose notion of territorial compromise contains some elements of a "land for peace" formula, was in a better situation to enter into negotiations with the Palestinian and eventually sign the 1993 Declaration of Principles (DOP) agreement. That agreement facilitated limited autonomy in the Gaza and Jericho areas for the Palestinians.

The United States presidential election in 1992 brought a new party, president and administration, but support for Israel remains firm. There is no likelihood of an ultimatum from Washington to pressure Israel and force her to withdraw from the 1967 occupied territories. As broker and co-sponsor of the December 1990 Madrid conference, the United States left the scene to the parties involved in the dispute to negotiate among themselves and reach a solution. One might say that the overall foreign policy of the United States toward the Palestinian question and the wider Israeli-Arab conflict has not changed. Neither Syrian president Assad nor Arafat was invited to visit President Clinton in Washington, and this reflects the lack of a breakthrough in the American-Arab relationship, though the US continues concerted efforts in various channels. Quandt (1994) suggests that the United States should take a more aggressive position promoting Palestinian democracy: "... the administration could say that its support for eventual Palestinian statehood would be commensurate with the Palestinian commitment to democracy" (Quandt 1994, 6). Nevertheless, the continuing military aid to Israel, and the refusal of the United States to drop UN sanctions against Iraq or to drop Syria from the "terrorist list" (Muslih 1994, 162) cannot be dissociated from American's basically one-sided position in the conflict.

Probably the most significant single change in the region beside the peace deal with Jordan and the Israel-PLO agreement is the relative but rapid rapprochement between Syria and the United States. Syria, after a history of close client-state ties to the former Soviet Union, made a significant step to shift directions and come closer to the United States (Lucas 1994). President Clinton's visit to

Syria in the summer 1994 can be viewed as an achievement of Syria's foreign policy in this direction. Khalidi (1992) notes that the relative "proximity [of Syria] to the US is itself an insurance policy of Syria against an Israeli attack" (Khalidi 1992, 224). Yet since Syria and Israel have already most probably negotiated some sort of clandestine peace, kept confidential, a war between the two antagonists in the near future seems unlikely. Yet geographic issues are at the heart of what separates Israel and Syria, namely the occupied and annexed Golan Heights. No doubt the coming months are a critically important phase for reaching peace or failing in the attempt (cf. Muslih 1994). The 1996 presidential elections in the United States and the 1996 Israeli Knesset election will have their own role in enhancing bilateral negotiations or complicating and even derailing the peace process, should *Likud* return to power. The conservative Republican Congress in Washington is staunchly pro-Israel, and the mid-May 1995 veto of a resolution condemning Israel's expropriation of Arab land near Jerusalem (see below) indicates just how strong that reinvigorated pro-Israel tilt is in a US government shifting to the right. This tendency will be strengthened if the Republicans can capture the White House in November 1996.

The Palestinians and the New World Order

"After forty years of ghostly wandering conflict in No Man's Land and twenty-one years of occupation, the Palestinians want to start laughing and stop crying. They want to breathe Palestinian oxygen, plough Palestinian soil, watch Palestinian skies, hear Palestinian accent. . . The Palestinians long ago crossed the threshold of nationhood. Their fortitude is geologically constituted. Time will not erode it and brutality will not domesticate it. The Palestinians are not becoming fewer but more numerous. They are not becoming less but more mobilized" (Khalidi 1992, 158).

The citation above, first published in 1989, has acquired a significant symbolic meaning with the arrival of the first troops of the Palestinian police to the autonomous areas of Gaza and Jericho in the spring of 1994, following the signing of the Cairo agreement on May 4, 1994 between Israel and the Palestine Liberation Organization (Document 1994). The return of several thousand Palestinians to their homelands from diaspora countries (ie, Yemen, Sudan, Iraq, Jordan and Egypt) signifies an important step toward possible ending of the one-hundred year conflict between Palestinians and Jews over Palestinian territory.

On the eve of the collapse of the Soviet Union, Palestinian nationalism entered a new phase. Confrontation with Israel shifted from outside Palestine into territories occupied by Israel. The Palestinian popular *Intifada* (uprising), which erupted in the West Bank and Gaza Strip in December 1987, has had a multi-dimensional impact on the request for ending Israel's twenty years of occupation and finding a proper solution to the Palestinian question. In the international arena, the *Intifada* met with widespread support for the Palestinian quest for self-

determination. In Israel, the *Intifada* has impressed upon Israeli public that the current status quo could not longer continue (Karsh 1994, 150). On the Palestinian side, the *Intifada* played a direct role in influencing the resolutions adopted by the Palestine National Council (PNC) in Algiers in November 1988 (Abdel Ruhman 1990). The 19th session of the PNC, held one year after the outbreak of the *Intifada*, accepted United Nations resolutions 242 and 338, and thus accepted the principle of a two-state solution – including the implicit acceptance of Israel's existence in pre-1967 borders³). It was during this session that the Declaration of Independence of the state of Palestine was issued, and later recognized by over one hundred states. According to Khalidi (1992) "by excluding the whole of pre-1967 Israel (77% of Mandatory Palestine) from their [ie, the Palestinians] claims, and by restricting their claims to only the Occupied Territories (a necessary corollary to their peace plan as announced in the Algiers PNC), the PLO and the Palestinians made towards Israel a concession of historic proportions in the interests of preserving their central core values of survival, existence, acceptance, and recognition" (p. 220). This declaration continues to attract support for the Palestinian course, coupled with increasing sympathy for those Palestinians who live in the West Bank and Gaza, and who are in daily confrontation with Israeli oppression.

El-Kholi et al. (1989) elaborated extensively upon the possibility of solving the Palestinian problem, shaped by the new changes in the world political system. The authors postulate that all signs of rapprochement between East and West are not necessarily working in favour of the Arab World interests, and thus the Arab World must advance its claims and exploit emerging gaps and differences between the superpowers.

El-Kholi et al. (1989) proposed that future Palestinian diplomacy toward the United States and Israel should concentrate on achieving three objectives: first, the Palestinian problem should be given top priority in the new American administration. Second, an attempt should be made to isolate the Israeli rightwing forces and present them as the major obstacle for peace in the Middle East. Third, an attempt should be made to help widen the gap between United States and Israel, in addition to widening a similar gap between Israel and the American Jews (p. 72).

In a similar vein, Abdel Ruhman (1990) discusses the changes in Palestinian strategy and politics in recent years within the context of worldwide new order. His reflections can be briefly summarised in six observations, all of which are aimed at minimizing Palestinian suffering and bringing about the birth of Palestinian state. These points are as follows: (1) The popular Palestinian *Intifada*: The *Intifada* is seen to have a major role in moderating and redefining a new Palestinian program for struggle for statehood. He does not elaborate much on this point, states that the *Intifada* challenged Israeli prolonged occupation, showing that the status quo could not continue. (2) In their struggle for statehood, the Palestinians have managed to place their claims on the political map of the Middle East. As such,

they are confronted with increasing demands to transform this achievement into an operational and meaningful solution. As reconciliation becomes a successful tool of conflict resolution elsewhere, the Palestinians should introduce their own initiative; otherwise they will be left alone without any solution. The worse that could happen is that the Arab world will make peace with Israel and abandon the Palestinians. (3) Israel's continuous strategy of colonisation and annexation of Arab lands in the West Bank and Gaza strip has worried the Palestinians that if a solution was delayed too long, there might be a situation that the rest of the Palestinian lands would be absorbed by Israel. There would then be no more lands remaining to bargain for. (4) The fourth point is related to the previous one. It suggests that Palestinian leadership realized that the establishment of a state on any piece of Palestinian lands is the most effective tool to prevent Israel's expansion strategy. Yet, once such a Palestinian state is effectively established, it will have its own empowerment to work toward achieving a final but satisfactory settlement to the Arab-Israel conflict. (5) In recent years, the position of Palestinian leadership has crystallized and been firmed up, especially since the breakout of the *Intifada*, with an increasing need for establishing a Palestinian state to cope with everyday hardships of the Palestinian people. The creation of the Palestinian state is seen here – in human and existential terms – as the only way to prevent further deterioration of the political, economic and social situation. (6) A new way of thinking among Arab and Palestinian sectors in approaching the Israeli-Palestinian conflict has recently emerged, with a new strategy of reconciliation. The ultimate end of this strategy is to penetrate – by means of peace and reconciliation--into Israeli society, to impact on its nationalist ideology and eventually assimilate it and integrate the Israelis, in a context of post-Zionism, into a wider Oriental Arab society. This approach also suggests that a two-state solution can be viewed as a tactics for creating new social and political circumstances in the region, in which pan-Arabism will likely revive once again, and as such will guarantee the demolition of the framework of the political program of Zionism. Moving forward on the basis of such a scenario, Palestinians will be in a better position to materialize their dreams and liberate all of Palestine.

The Palestinian Stance in the Gulf Crisis

The invasion of Iraqi army into Kuwait and the subsequent Gulf War and its outcome diverted international attention from the western half of the fertile crescent to its eastern side. During the initial weeks of the crisis, events in the Gulf succeeded in almost fully eclipsing the *Intifada* which was in its thirty-third month (Abed 1991, 33). The Palestinian stance in the war was clouded by both disinformation and applied disinformation. It was politicised and propoganzed in many directions, often reflecting the political agenda of the

writers and their site of representation. A better understanding of the Palestinian position of the crisis should start by distinguishing between three issues in the crisis, as noted by El-Kholi (1991, 18-19). First, there was the issue of the Iraqi occupation of Kuwait, which it neither defended nor supported. This stand does not mean that the Palestinian people together with its organisation and leadership, supported the Iraqi occupation of Kuwait. Such support for aggression would have defeated its own cause against the Israeli occupation, an impossible stance for a people that has such a legacy of struggle, or depth of experience and awareness for almost a century. Second, there was the Iraqi missile bombardment of the Israeli enemy that occupied its land, which it both defended and supported. And, lastly, there was the destruction of Iraq and its potential as an Arab country by the military machine of the US-led alliance, which it condemned as exceeding the limits of any legitimate international liberation of Kuwait. There was, however, a wide range of opinion and there was never an official Palestinian policy to support the invasion. Abdel Maguid's (1991) is the most comprehensive study to elaborate upon such diversity of opinion. He recognised the difficulties of pointing out to a unified Palestinian stance on the Gulf crisis, though one may notice the existence of a broad line of Palestinian support for Iraqi policy – or at least sympathy for that policy and its underlying motives.

Abdel Maguid (1991) analyzed the Palestinian position in terms of three different modes. First, that of the PLO leadership and its factions: at the beginning of the crisis, the PLO tried to take part as a mediator, and thus adopt a position to support a proposal for solving the crisis within the framework of the Arab states – regionally – and without external intervention. For pragmatic reasons, it did not side either with Iraq or Kuwait. Yet, the emergence of a PLO position supportive of Iraq was cultivated during a meeting of the foreign ministers of Arab states in Cairo on the second day of the crisis. While the general position of Arab states (especially Egypt and Saudia Arabia) was to condemn the Iraqi invasion and request an unconditional withdrawal of the Iraqi army from Kuwait, the PLO refrained from such a direct anti-Iraqi stance. This stance was compatible with other Arab states, such as Jordan and Yemen, which were reluctant to condemn Iraq, hopefully leaving the door open for further inter-Arab dialogue. As time past and Arab relations deteriorated, the PLO position became even more pro-Iraqi. Despite various attempts by PLO prominent members (eg Mahmud Abass, Jamal Surani, Juwaid el Ghasin, Salah Khalaf, Khalid al-Hassan, Hani al-Hassan and Nabil Sha'ith) to come up with proposals to reject in principle the Iraqi invasion of Kuwait, PLO Chairman, Yasser Arafat left the Palestinian position unchanged. Apparently, this policy was calculated as a bid to wait for better circumstances. Abed (1991, 34) postulates that such treatment of the crisis by the PLO caused much damage to the Palestinians and "could have been ameliorated, had the Palestinian political leadership taken a clear and more forthright stand on the crisis".

Second, there was the unified national leadership of the *Intifada* and the Islamic Jihad group. The position of this group was marked by clearer support for Iraq. The emphasis on support of Iraq emanated basically from the perception of being forced to confront an imperial enemy, ie, the United States. This group used a discourse of condemnation analogous to that used by the Iraqis, such as the notion that imperial power was grabbing for Arab natural resources, and would attempt to place those resources in the safe hands of coopted Arab leaders.

Third, there was the Islamic Hamas movement. At the beginning of the crisis, the Hamas movement appeared to side somewhat with Iraq. It condemned the external foreigner intervention and regarded the huge assembly of western forces in the Gulf as a humiliation for the Arab and Muslim nation, and not only the Iraqis. Later (early September 1990), Hamas issued another but more balanced statement that called for simultaneous withdrawal of all armies – the Iraqi forces from Kuwait versus the foreign forces from the region. Hamas suggested that Arab and Moslem forces should be dispatched to the war fronts. In the same statement, Hamas also stressed its sympathy with the Kuwaitis by stating that “we in Palestine recognize more than any body else the bitterness of the loss of homeland and the pain of dispersal and diaspora” (Abdel Maguid 1991, 181). Hamas advocated a solution to the crisis within an Arabic-Islamic framework in which Iraq could present its claims against Kuwait.

To conclude this discussion, there was considerable diversity in the Palestinian position on the crisis. It is natural that some Palestinians saw in the Gulf crisis an opportunity to advance Palestinian claims through a ‘package deal’ solution, ending all military occupations in all occupied regions. Such a solution, if materialized, would end the Syrian army presence in Lebanon and end all Israeli occupation in areas in southern Lebanon, the Syrian Golan heights and the Palestinian West Bank and Gaza strip. There were, however, some Palestinians (like many non-Palestinian Arabs) who had the illusion that Iraq possessed a ‘secret’ weapon that would turn the war to her favour and, as a result, eventually bring (or force) Israel to respond positively to Palestinian demands for statehood. The voice of Palestinians who lived in Kuwait, North America, Europe and many Arab countries who were against the invasion into Kuwait was hardly heard. This was not only because PLO chairman Arafat did not manage to keep his distance from Saddam Husein during the critical period, but most importantly because of the Western (and Israeli) media, which chose to highlight this contact between the two leaders, constructing an image of Palestinian-Iraqi solidarity that did not exist in totality. Israel used the Gulf crisis to signal to the Arab world that Israel was not their only enemy (Karsh 1994). At the same time, it tried to systematically liken itself to the situation of Kuwait: both were being attacked by a single enemy of the entire region. In Israel, the Israeli media associated the Palestinians collectively with the constructed metaphor of “Palestinians cheering from the

roofs” while the Iraqi scuds were in the air on their way to Tel Aviv (Portugali 1993, 176-177).

The political agenda covert in this metaphor should be seen as more than just the building of an image of purported support for Saddam Hussein. It is a manifestation of Israel’s interpretation of threat and security (Falah and Newman 1995). The Palestinians were presented in this case as a war-loving people, full of hatred for the Jews. At the same time, Israel was represented as a country under seige, victimized, a recurrent topos in Israeli national consciousness and historical memory. An Israeli geographer, Yuval Portugali, fashioned one of the more distorted thesis when he drew on this metaphor by saying that “Saddam promised the Palestinians a second Jewish Holocaust ... and none of their political leaders and intellectuals dared say a word against it” (p. 176-177). Without questioning the truth in this allegation, this statement cannot be taken seriously when scores of Tel Avivian Jewish families left their houses and went to Palestinian villages in Israel, hosted and welcomed by their Palestinian friends (eg, in Taiyiba and Baqa el Gharbiya). There is no mention whatsoever in Portugali’s work of such events, which are well-documented. Moreover, the fact that during the entire war period (over forty days), Palestinians in the Occupied Territories were forced to live under a continuous curfew was also overlooked by Portugali. Isn’t it possible that Palestinians in the Occupied Territories went up to the roof of their houses because they were forbidden to walk in the streets day and night, pent up in their dwellings? Isn’t it possible that in situation like that, and just because of simple human reaction, people will follow a common sense which says: “Your enemy is my friend”? The mass psychology of long-term occupation is complex.

It is true that before the crisis began, Iraq was the main financial source for the *Intifada* (Abed 1991) and there was mutual rapprochement between Iraqi and Palestinian interests. The Iraqis were in a position to lead the Arab world after their triumph over Iran, reviving a new pan-Arabism on their terms. In this context, the Palestinian problem acquired a certain importance in Iraqi rhetoric. However, by bombarding Tel-Aviv, the Iraqi leader’s aims overlapped somewhat with Palestinian interests, but were primarily intended to change the nature of the crisis, converting it into an Arab-Israeli and American conflict (Freedman 1993). If this scenario had succeeded, Iraq would have certainly been able to crack open the coalition between the Arab states and the US forces, because it would have been a great embarrassment for Syria, for example, to fight Iraq side-by-side with Israel.

As the war ended and the Kuwaitis regained their country, the Palestinians in Kuwait were forced to pay the full price for the crisis. They were expelled, cleansed from Kuwait, and some lost their lives. According to the New York-based Middle East Watch, the Palestinian expulsion from Kuwait “represented the third major displacement in Palestinian history” (cited in The Center for Policy Analysis on Palestine 1992, 15). Prior to the Gulf crisis in 1990, the

number of Palestinians residing in Kuwait were estimated at about 350,000-400,000. As of September 1991, between 50,000-80,000 Palestinians remained in Kuwait. By the summer of 1992, the figure dwindled to around 30,000 (The Center for Policy Analysis on Palestine 1992, 15).

Toward a New Peace Strategy

Whatever the "Palestinian position" on the Gulf War was, the quest for an immediate solution to the Palestinian plight has become more pressing. The *Intifada* in the West Bank and Gaza Strip continued for some time. The economic constraint and hardship which accompanied the *Intifada* had its own role in pressuring the PLO leadership to accommodate itself to the sweeping changes in political circumstances. The few options that remain credible within an international arena dominated by the United States suddenly became limited (El Kholi 1991, 16-17). The PLO and Palestinian leaders from the Occupied Territories had to respond and adopt a new strategy for resuming talks with the United States. On the other hand, the Israeli government under Shamir realised that the PLO position had deteriorated politically. They exploited the opportunity to dictate conditions on the Palestinians for attending the 1991 Madrid peace conference (Green 1991). For example, Israel stipulated (and received what was demanded) that no independent Palestinian delegation should attend the conference but should be part of 'Jordanian-Palestinian delegation'. Israel demanded that none of the Palestinian representatives should have an official link with the PLO and should not be a resident of East Jerusalem. From the Palestinian perspective, it became clear that such preconditions imposed by Israel were calculated to invite a negative response on the part of the PLO and the Palestinian side, who were at that time in regular contact with the US Secretary of State James Baker (El Kholi 1991, 16). What probably went unnoticed by the Shamir government was the extent to which the PLO had become more pragmatic and flexible, especially after being excluded from the negotiations. Shortly after talks were started in Madrid and continued in Washington, DC, the Israeli delegates began to realise the deep involvement of the PLO in the negotiations. While the Palestinian negotiators were formally assigned to be part of other delegation ie, Jordanian, they were in effect carrying with them a PLO mandate. Needless to say, it was the 'PLO budget' in Tunis that covered all related expenses during these negotiations.

Despite the fact that the Shamir government dictated conditions at that time and has done little to advance a genuine peace (Shlaim 1994a), the Palestinians were able to manoeuvre and successfully present their agenda. Having accepted United Nations Resolutions 242 and 338 – on the basis of which Israel must withdraw from the 1967 Occupied Territories and give way for Palestinian self-determination – the Palestinians are in a good position to present their claims. This in itself signifies a new strategy for peace.

The Palestinian presence in Madrid, Washington DC, and elsewhere was founded on three basic assumptions: 1) No deals with Israel on the part of any Arab state could be concluded at the expense of the Palestinians. If such an attempt was perceived, the Palestinians were there to reject it and raise their voice. 2) To expose Israel's negative position to the worldwide community as a country which did not want to make genuine peace with the Palestinians. 3) The Palestinian representatives, though formally not part of the PLO, did not claim or attempt to bypass the PLO role as the sole legitimate representative of the Palestinian people. Contextually, Israel's objectives of excluding the PLO in practical terms did not materialise. In fact, the Palestinian representatives never missed an opportunity for stating that the 'final word' in any decisions is in the hands of the PLO, and they will not be prepared to circumvent such an order.

It is clear that the September 1993 White House meeting of the Israeli and the Palestinian leaders and the subsequent mutual recognition between Israel and the PLO was a turning point in the Arab-Israeli conflict (Karsh 1994, 143). Unlike the previous Israeli-Egyptian mutual recognition and the Camp David accord where Egypt found itself severely accused of making a separate 'deal' with the Arab enemy, and was eventually expelled from the Arab League, the PLO recognition of Israel had less impact and generated much less condemnation on the part of the Arab countries. For the White House ceremony, the American administration managed to gather representatives from most of the Arab states. On other fronts, the Clinton Administration exercised its power to persuade many Arab states to support a PLO-Israeli agreement, or at least not to oppose it. This, in turn, indirectly helped the PLO Chairman Arafat to tour several Arab capitals and explain the Palestinian position in the deal with Israel.

While Israel gained formal legitimacy from the Palestinian leadership to exist as a state in the land of Palestine, the Palestinians right to self-determination was also furthered, and now Israel is committed to talk directly with the PLO with regard to Palestinian issues, ending its policy of over thirty years of searching for alternative representatives. Moreover, for the first time, Palestinian self-determination has peacefully led to territorial gains, ie, the Israeli army effectively withdrew from certain areas and handed them over to the Palestinian authority.

Although the limited autonomy arrangement proposed in the Gaza and Jericho areas did not explicitly spell out the establishment of a Palestinian state, it was directly linked to the United Nations resolutions 242 and 338. One should note that the ultimate implementation of these two resolutions involves complete Israeli withdrawal from all the territories occupied in 1967. Moreover, such linkages are a crucial element for Palestinian acceptance of the temporary autonomy arrangement, and even the recognition of Israel. This notion was made clear in the opening paragraphs of the DOP, signed in Washington DC September 13, 1993 and the Cairo Agreement of May 4th, 1994. The Washington, DC, agreement states that:

"[t]he aim of the Israeli-Palestinian negotiations within the current Middle East peace process is, among other things, to establish a Palestinian Interim Self-Government Authority ... for the Palestinian people in the West Bank and Gaza Strip, for a transitional period not exceeding five years, leading to a permanent settlement based on Security Council Resolutions 242 and 338 (Document 1993).

The Cairo agreement on the other hands state the following:

"Reaffirming their understanding that the self governments ... are an integral part of the whole peace process and that the negotiations on the permanent status will lead to the implementation of Security Council Resolutions 242 and 338" (Document 1994).

There has been extensive analysis of the 1993 Israeli-PLO agreement. Articles (Maiallat al-Dirasat al-Filastiniya, No. 16, 1993; Dajani 1994; Said 1994; Shlaim 1994b; Perlmutter 1995) cover a wide range of opinions over the specific timing of the agreements, its ambiguous text, Israel-PLO power disparity, the participants in the negotiations and the overall weaknesses and strength from both perspectives –Israeli and Palestinian. For geographers, the agreement itself and its wording is of secondary interest; primary is how it can be translated into actual territorial behaviour. Geographers are also interested, for example, in assessing the obstacles that prevent the implementation of the territorial aspect of the agreement. This, *inter alia*, includes ideas and information about the way in which one party exercises its power and creates conditions aimed at bypassing certain aspects of the agreement, eventually declining to transfer territories to the other. Given the record of a long history of a lack of mutual confidence between Israelis and Palestinians, there will be many intervening forces to suppress the complete and smooth implementation of the autonomy agreement. What one party has failed to gain throughout negotiations can now be achieved through the implementation process. To be sure, there will be intervening forces and issues invented by both sides in order to advance or suppress certain conditions in the agreement. Each party will look to what serves their immediate interest, regardless of the agreement's text. In such a situation, a discourse of accusation and counter-accusation will prevail, accompanying all future negotiations. Both partners will continue to maneuver for gain, but will not go so far as to sacrifice the 'deal' altogether.

Palestinian Territorial Behaviour in the Near Future

For the Palestinians, the way to achieve full sovereignty is still long and strewn with many obstacles. Israel and the PLO decided to delay negotiations on three very thorny issues: Jerusalem, the status of Jewish settlements in the West Bank and Gaza Strip, and the fate of over three million refugees and displaced Palestinians currently living outside Palestine. In all three issues, the Palestinian side has clear backing from the specific United Nation resolution and international law (Cattan 1981; Mallison & Mallison 1986; Lustick 1993-94). Without a satisfactory

solution to these three issues, it is clear that there will be no real peace in the Middle East. From the Palestinian perspective, Jerusalem is a zero-sum game, ie, it is the future capital of Palestine and thus non-negotiable. As a united city, it was governed continuously by a Palestinian Moslem mayor from the time of the Caliph Omar Ibn El Khattab (seventh century) until 1948, with the exception of a short period when the Crusaders conquered the city (Abcarius 1946, 124). Among the Palestinians, there appears to be a consensus that no Palestinian leader has the authority or the power to convince his people to choose an alternative capital for the state of Palestine.

One should make a distinction between the part of the city called East Jerusalem and that of Arab Jerusalem. The two terms are geographically distinct in reference. 'East Jerusalem' refers to the part of the city which was separated by the 1949 armistice line and placed under Jordanian control from 1949 until June 5, 1967. Yet the boundary of Arab Jerusalem constitutes a much larger territory, including additional Arab property and lands found today in West Jerusalem. The map prepared by Sir William Fitzgerald Committee provides a picture of the Arab part of Jerusalem in the late years of the Mandate. In 1946, the Palestine Government appointed the 'Fitzgerald Commission' to consider and make recommendations for the division of Jerusalem into Arab and Jewish municipal sectors. The Report of the Commission, with its corresponding map, were published in the Palestine Gazette Extraordinary No. 1541, 12 December 1946 (Government of Palestine 1946). The territorial divisions proposed in this report can serve as a basis for the future negotiations between the Israelis and the Palestinians. If Jerusalem should remain a united city, where its western and eastern sections form the capital of Israel and Palestine respectively, the Palestinians who lived in the city before 1948 must have the right to return to their homes or receive compensation.

The Jewish settlements established in the West Bank and Gaza are both the symbol and outcome of twenty-eight years of Israeli occupation of the territories. There is a consensus among governments (including that of Israel) that the Regulations of the 1907 Hague Convention IV are applicable to the territories occupied by Israel, including the West Bank and Gaza strip. The vast majority of states also agree that the Fourth Geneva Convention (1949) applies to the West Bank and Gaza. The government of Israel does not accept the applicability of the Geneva Convention, because it does not accept that the West Bank and Gaza are "occupied" in the sense of the Geneva Convention; however, Israel has said it will respect the "humanitarian provisions" of the Geneva Convention, without defining what these are (Coon 1992, 36). From the Palestinian standpoint, all Jewish settlements in the West Bank and Gaza Strip must be removed, and those who desire to stay put and live under the sovereignty of the state of Palestine have to accept the laws of the new state. Those settlements built on lands belonging to the nearby Palestinian villages and towns have to return the lands to

their rightful owners, and pay adequate compensation for years of land use. The new Palestinian state is expected to carry out a complete registration of land and property, and there could be an extensive revision of the current land tenure.

The fate of the Palestinian refugees is another difficult issue that will have to be addressed soon. Unlike other refugees, Palestinian refugees are not seeking a place of residence other than their country of origin. Their main wish is to be allowed, should they so choose, to return to their own homeland (Zureik 1994, 8). The Palestinian right of return to their homeland was confirmed in numerous United Nations resolutions, most significantly Paragraph 11 of Resolution 194 of 11 December 1948, which states that the General Assembly:

Resolve[s] that the refugees wishing to return to their homes and live at peace with their neighbours should be permitted to do so at the earliest practicable date, and that compensation should be paid for the property of those choosing to return and for loss of or damage to property which, under principles of international law in equity, should be made good by the governments or authorities responsible ... (cited in Salam 1994, 20).

This resolution has been annually reaffirmed by the UN General Assembly, which has further endorsed the right of return on the basis of resolution 194 in a number of other resolutions. According to Salam (1994) "... no less than forty General Assembly resolutions have reaffirmed Article 11 of Resolution 194; UNGA Resolution 3236 of 1974 elevated the right of return for the first time to the rank of an "inalienable right" (p. 21).

The Palestinian peace strategy since 1988 suggests that a Palestinian state will be established in a part of Palestine which constitutes the West Bank and Gaza Strip – an area which forms less than of one-quarter of historic Palestine. This strategy should not infringe on the right of Palestinians to live in areas today under the control of Israel. If individual Palestinians are not prepared to accept monetary compensation and are determined to live in former villages and towns, they should be given the option to do so. The Palestinian refugee problem is essentially a territorial issue, not simply a question of a shortage of housing. Currently in the Gaza strip, the population is over 70% refugees, and there is no more space to settle additional population. It is also one of most densely populated micro areas in the world (Newman and Falah 1995). On the other hand, the West Bank remains the only viable place to absorb some one million refugees, most of whom would be those Palestinians who fled the area during the 1967 war. As such, there is a need to 'bargain' for additional territory within Israel itself. Such territory would be areas adjacent and with territorial continuity to the West Bank and Gaza Strip (Fig 1) – specifically, the area which was occupied by Israel in the 1948/49 War and added to the area assigned to the Jewish state according to United Nations Partition Proposal of November 1947. Significantly, the area assigned to the Jewish state in the 1947 UN Proposal amounted to 56% of Palestine⁴. This area was enlarged by 37% from the 14,900 sq. km to 20,500 sq. km. as

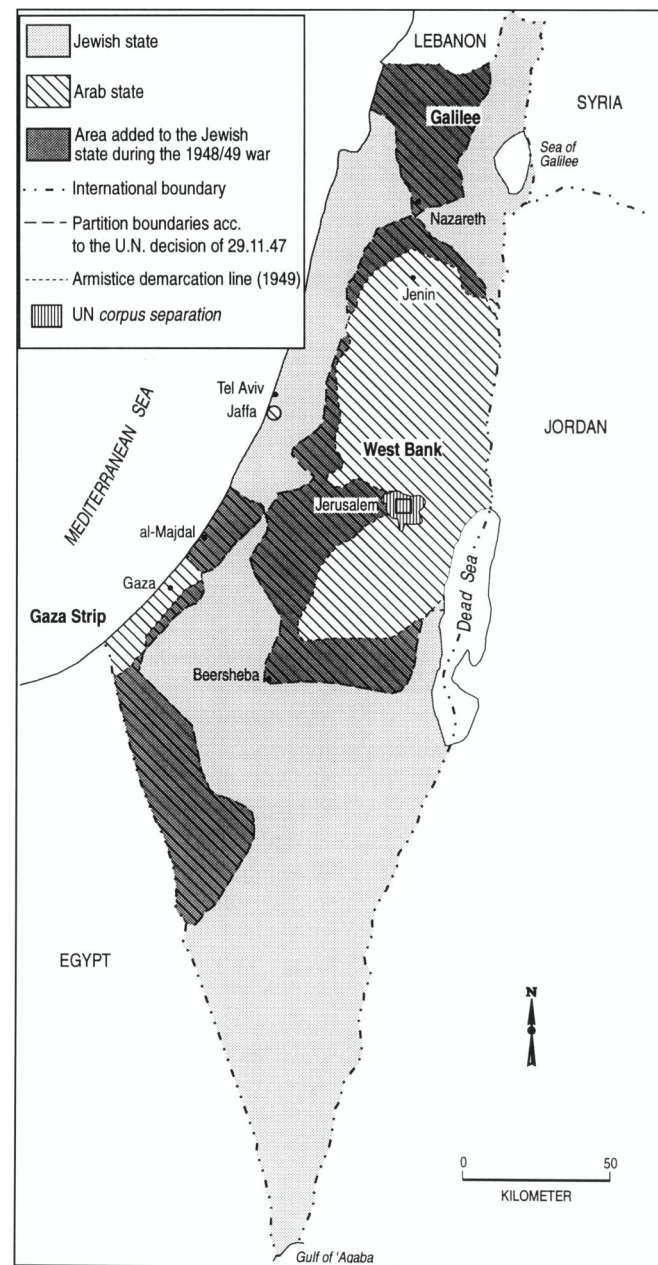


Fig 1 Map of United Nations Partition Recommendation (1947), West Bank and Gaza Strip

a result of the 1948 War. Israel has never officially defined the exact delimitations of its border line, partly because the state often found itself in a war situation or because there was a hidden agenda to acquire additional territory by a peace agreement or otherwise. From this perspective, the areas added during the 1948 war to the 1947 Jewish state as spelled out by the Partition Plan can still be considered disputed territory. If Israel has always envisioned possibilities for pushing the 'green line border' towards the east, south and even west, as based on Israel's pre-1967 territory?

Within the boundary of this new area, the prospect for settling Palestinian refugees is most desirable. One should distinguish here between (a) the demand to settle Palestinian refugees in this specific area added to the West Bank or Gaza Strip as part of the Palestinian right of return, and (b) the changing legal status of the area. Theoretically speaking, the former could be attained without changing the status of Israel's territory in this sub-area. Israel can still be sovereign over this area. Yet, in order to achieve the first goal, ie, settlement of Palestinian refugees, a situation could arise in which Israel voluntarily agrees to cede territory to the West Bank or Gaza. An alternative situation would be that Israel and the Palestinians agree that this sub-area should be under shared Israeli-Palestinian control. In such a case, the pattern of a condominium arrangement could be applicable.

Looking at the challenges facing the Palestinians to achieve a sovereign state, three territorial behaviour alternatives can be envisioned. First, the Palestinians will continue "bargaining" with Israel and ultimately force Israel to end its occupation of the West Bank and Gaza. This can happen through the expansion of the autonomy areas in Gaza and Jericho to embrace the whole West Bank and Gaza Strip. The Palestinian strategy during the stage of autonomy should be concentrated on creating facts of their own (building new cities, villages, resort areas, communication lines, etc.) and resist further encroachments on their lands by Israel. They should rebuild a new working relation with both Jordan and Egypt (with whom Israel has made peace) and persuade the two countries to let Israel know that her peace with them will be in question if Israel's settlement strategy is not halted. With regard to Jerusalem, the Palestinians could mobilize the Moslem world on their behalf. They also could remind President Clinton and the American administration that his citations of the Kor'an during the White House ceremony of 13 September 1993 - ie, "the Koran teaches that if the enemy inclines toward peace, do thou also incline toward peace" (Journal of Palestine Studies 1994, 120) - should become reality. Washington must declare its opposition to continuous expropriations of Arab lands in East Jerusalem and elsewhere by Israel in the occupied territories.

At the time of writing (May, 1995), the Israeli government has approved a large expropriation of Arab lands in East Jerusalem at two sites. One is an area of 335 dunams (33 hectares) in the north, between the post-1967 Jewish suburb of Ramot and the Arab village of Beit Hanina. The other is 200 dunams in the south, next to the Arab village of Beit Safafa. These expropriations have generated vehement protest on the part of the Palestinians and many Arab countries, especially Jordan. A motion by France was submitted to the United Nations to cancel this expropriation. As a response, the Palestinian National authority urged all Arab states to cease their contact with Israel unless the confiscations are cancelled (The Economist, May 6th 1995, 41). On May 17, the US used its veto in the Security Council (for the first time in five years) to block a motion condemning the Israeli moves.

Second, once the Palestinians have obtained full autonomy in the West Bank and Gaza, the road to sovereignty is significantly shortened. The Palestinian authority at this stage must gear itself toward establishing a viable state (Fischer 1993-94; Avineri 1994; Newman and Falah 1995). Nonetheless, I do not wish to suggest here that the Palestinian authority must delay development until the achievement of complete autonomy or sovereignty. This would be a self-defeating strategy. Development should start now - without any further delay. The Palestinian diaspora should be involved in the process of state building. Their involvement should not be confined only to capital investment and creating projects; they should also be an actual participant in the establishment of democracy and law. The Palestinians in Israel are another group with unique experience and qualifications, and should also be involved. This segment of the Palestinian people was long discriminated by Israel, and its treatment even today is often in violation of various civil rights and liberties (Schechla 1993). It is time now that they contribute and benefit by providing special task forces to channel input into civil administrations, government institutions, etc. Their role should not be as marginal advisors to some ministry. Rather, they should play a role in the process of building a Palestinian state, as equal as any other Palestinians. Most importantly, Palestinians should establish a wide range of social programmes to effect an ingathering of the far-flung Palestinian diaspora as quickly as possible. Social programmes should be hammered out and implemented. Such programs will have immense impact in encouraging young Palestinians to come and settle in the new Palestine. Ideological differences among Palestinians must remain within the framework of reasonable democratic debate. Palestinian energy should be husbanded, and not frittered away at such a critical time when the world awaits the Palestinian state to be born. Should the Palestinians reorganise themselves in the coming few years and learn from their experience negotiating with Israel, they are likely to be in a better bargaining situation.

Third, as noted earlier, the Palestinian refugee problem cannot be solved territorially only within the framework of the West Bank and Gaza Strip areas. An additional strip of territory from Israel is needed. This issue should be raised now. In an increasingly post-Zionizing climate, Israelis should come more and more to realize the wisdom of the proverb in Jewish scripture (Pr. 27, 10): Better a neighbour that is near than a brother far off. It is not premature to discuss this issue now, since it is intrinsically linked to the refugee's right of return. The Palestinians themselves should learn to think that this option is not utopian but realizable, and the Israelis should be persuaded that it is in their interest to settle the Palestinians refugees in places they choose, that they can shape Palestinian geography in the interest of both parties. In their turn, the Palestinian government can translate the request for additional areas to be added to the West Bank and Gaza Strip into concrete territorial behaviour.

If the Palestinian government can be convinced that additional area from Israel should be requested for settling the Palestinian refugees – an area marked out by the borders of the area added to the 1947 Partition Plan Jewish state during the 1948/49 War – then concrete measures should be taken in addition to negotiations. Here the Palestinian government can resolve to act, moving in several directions. For example, when the issue of refugees is raised and demands for implementation of UN Resolution 194 put forward, the Palestinians should insist that only actual return of Palestinian refugees to this area is acceptable, and that no monetary compensation in lieu can be considered. The Palestinian government can also attempt to create a consensus among former residents of Palestinian towns and villages of this area that no compensation is permitted. There must be resettlement on land. Legally, there might be ways in which the Palestinian government can anchor the issue of compensation in a new law in which certain areas are defined as of “permitted”, “restricted” or “no compensation accepted at all”. These suggestions are not the only ones possible, and have been put forward to point out directions towards desirable territorial behaviour – and to encourage the Palestinian government to be motivated to establish a more comprehensive, elaborated and better calibrated compensation system. Concomitantly, Israel could be encouraged to consider a massive resettlement program to establish Jewish urban centers in some parts of the Naqab desert now sparsely inhabited by Jews and Palestinian Arabs, and in the vast (200 km) and nearly empty Araba Valley running south of the Dead Sea down to Eilat. This was the dream of early Zionist planners, particularly David Ben-Gurion, and despite repeated lip service, little has been done to direct Jewish settlement or attract high-tech industry to these relatively empty and still arid areas. A reapportionment of land and redrawing of boundaries with an aim to creating a viable Palestinian state should involve new angles for shifting some Jewish population elsewhere in the lopsidedly settled Jewish state, and encouraging extensive Jewish settlement in much of Israel’s unsettled south, now used mainly by the Israeli Defense Forces. There is not a single development town in the entire Araba, or anywhere in the central and southern Naqab between tiny Mitzpeh Ramon and Eilat. The peace with Jordan will make serious expansion of Jewish settlement in the Araba increasingly more attractive, such as a major town opposite the site of ancient Petra and near other ancient Nabatean mini-urban desert foci. The geography of water should not prove a major barrier. Magnet settlements could lure Israelis from the increasingly overcrowded central region, the Galilee and the occupied West Bank to a large part of the Jewish state under the 1947 partition plan that is still basically desolate, the principal dream of Ben-Gurion finally back on the concrete agenda in the name of a final peace.

Admittedly, such proposals and unilateral steps will surely trigger negative reactions on the part of Israel when publicly announced by the Palestinians. To make demands

more forceful, the Palestinians themselves should be motivated to refuse to accept monetary compensation; rather they must insist on their right of return to areas requested from Israel – ie, basically the area designated by the 1947 Partition Plan as an Arab State. Discourse on Palestine’s future boundaries and territory must move now toward such an inclusion of compensation and right of return as part of the altered dialogue, and alternative maps must be brought into play and circulation. Part of the revamped discourse can involve the request for massive international aid to Israel for building the Araba and southern Naqab, compensating Palestinian refugees and resettling Israelis.

This proposal is, to my knowledge, the first to address the Palestinian refugee problem directly and to introduce a strategy for refusal of compensation so as to preserve territory for future expansion of a viable Palestinian state. I have no doubt that many Israelis, and especially those in the right-wing camp, will interpret my advice to the Palestinian government as a step-by-step strategy to claim all of Palestine and put an end to the state of Israel. In other words, the Israeli rhetoric of “if you give the Arabs a little, they will ask for more” will likely associate with my suggestion. This kind of accusation can be easily refuted by underscoring the fact that Palestinians are readily prepared to make compromise and accept compensation for the loss of villages and towns in certain areas. This readiness on their part is itself proof of the Palestinian good-will in their commitment to the strategy of a two-state solution involving two viable states, not just a truncated mini-Palestine. Labor Zionists may feel a bit uneasy reminded of Ben-Gurionian concerns about shifting Jewish settlement southward to make a still arid desert “bloom”. At the same time, there will probably be Palestinians who think these suggestions should be presented first to the Palestinian authorities, and not indiscretely in print to a wider audience. Such reactions, if they occur, will attest to the fact that I have succeeded in some small measure in influencing the discourse and making people on both sides of the dispute at least aware of the utility of reading and rethinking maps--and maybe even of the value in listening to political geographers and the insights of their applied analysis.

Concluding Summary

In this essay, an attempt was made to speculate on various aspects of the Middle East political geography in the years 2000. The state as a single territorial unit was chosen as the main focus of the analysis. It could not be fully understood without linking its domestic political forces with both regional and superpower policies. In the context of the Middle East, the analysis becomes more complicated because of the involvement of pan-Arabism and Islamism. These latter forces serve dual functions that pull in opposite directions. On the other hand, they promote unification for the people living in the region

under supra-state interests, religious ideology and Arab nationalism. They also act as an external centrifugal force challenging the unity and loyalty of the people on the state level. Pan-Arabism and Islamism also had an impact on interstate political relationships. Western and superpower intervention in the Middle East theoretically should accelerate nationalist and Islamist reactions, and thus indirectly minimize fragmentation. In practice, both forces failed to unite the whole Middle East (or the Arab world), so the region remains politically fractured. This reality is not a cultural or an inevitable feature peculiar to the Arabs in the region, and is likely to change in the future with the introduction of true democracy and popular participation. The Palestinian case was examined in this essay to illustrate at least three common denominators between the Palestinians and the rest of the Middle East states and people, all governed by the spillover effect of the new world order. First, domestic social, political and economic issues of most states in the regions and intra-state relation are highly influenced by perceptions of Western discourse. A local leader's popularity can be in question if he or she does not meet Western expectations, and especially that of the Americans. Second, the focus on domestic problems and the keen desire of all Arab governments to attain a certain standard of stability have heightened the importance of state as a viable institution and increased its cultural distinctiveness. Third, the Palestinians and most of the states in the region were positively prepared to make readjustments in their foreign policies and accommodate themselves within the framework of changing circumstances and the new world order. After the Gulf War, the Palestinians made a major effort not to be isolated from any prospect of peaceful solution to the Middle East conflict. This in turn has resulted in the mutual recognition between Israel and the PLO. It is true that the Israelis and the Palestinians have signed a 'deal' of mutual recognition.

This in itself is important, but cannot be a guarantor of lasting peace. Land must be exchanged for durable peace. However the Rabin government tries to dictate conditions and exploit the relatively weak Palestinians authority, there will be no compromise on the part of the Palestinians to give up their claim to Jerusalem and complete withdrawal from the 1967 Occupied West Bank and Gaza Strip. The suggestion for additional areas to be taken from historic Palestine (now Israel) and added to the West Bank and Gaza to form a more territorially 'viable space' for Palestinian self-determination should not be seen as mere academic exercise, nor is it the official position of the present Palestinian authority. The proposal outlined here is meant as an example of applied political geography, a set of working suggestions to make a more just peace and finally put an end to almost five decades of forced diaspora for over three million Palestinians in exile. One key aim of all research on Palestine must be its application, instrumentalized as a tool for resolving the concrete problems of Palestinians.

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Notes

- ¹⁾ The original draft of this essay was written in February 1992-one year after the Gulf War ended (Falah 1992), and a shorter version was published elsewhere (Falah 1993). Writing from the perspective of April 1995, I intend to retain the spirit and thrust of the original, updating my text where relevant. A new section on the Palestinian peace strategy has been added.
- ²⁾ The literature on pan-Arabism is vast. Elie Chalala's article cited in the Reference list provides a most comprehensive review of such literature.
- ³⁾ These resolutions, passed following the June 1967 war between Israel and the three Arab countries of Syria, Jordan and Egypt, call for the rights of all peoples to self-determination, for Israel to return all occupied territory, and for all parties to recognize the legality of pre-war international boundaries.
- ⁴⁾ The UN Partition Plan of November 1947 called for establishing three entities in Palestine. A Jewish state was to have 56% of mandate Palestine; an Arab state was to have 43%; and a small enclave comprising Jerusalem was to be UN-administered internationalized zone. It should be mentioned here that the total area for today's West Bank and Gaza Strip territories comprise only 23% of the total area of mandatory Palestine.

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Report

News about Rice and People

New Rice Plant not yet Available in Farmers' Fields

Seeds of the new rice plant, popularly known as "super rice", are not yet available for planting in farmers' fields. What the International Rice Research Institute (IRRI) in Los Baños developed and harvested are prototype breeding lines of the rice plant which are currently being field-tested at IRRI.

Dr. Gurdev S. Khush, IRRI's principal plant breeder, clarified that the new plant type as it is now, is still susceptible to diseases and insects and further research and tests are aimed at the incorporation of disease and insect resistance and improving the grain quality. Thus, the new rice plant will not be available to farmers for another five years.

The new plant type was conceptualized in 1988. Breeding work was started in 1989 when about 2,000 varieties from the IRRI germplasm bank were grown to identify donor plants for various traits. Hybridization work was undertaken in 1990. Since then, more than 1,300 crosses have been made. About 65,000 breeding lines have been produced and plant types with desired traits have been selected. In a relatively short period of five years, the new desired plant type became available in 1994.

"Scientists at IRRI are attempting to breed resistance to pests and diseases into it while further research by scientists in

national research institutions, like the Philippine Rice Research Institute (PhilRice) in the Philippines, will then incorporate other desirable characteristics - such as those specific to taste - to meet individual country requirements," Dr. Khush added.

"When finally made available to farmers and coupled with promising fertilizer management technology, the new rice plant will likely produce on the same amount of land with the same amount of fertilizer - under ideal conditions - 25% more grains than the current high-yielding varieties," Dr. Khush said.

After fine tuning, field evaluation and seed multiplication, new plant type lines will be available for on-farm production by the turn of the century.

IRRI is an autonomous, nonprofit, international agricultural research and training center that carries out rice and rice-related research and is concerned about maintaining and increasing rice production worldwide. IRRI is supported by the Consultative Group on International Agricultural Research (CGIAR), an association of public and private donor agencies that funds 16 international agricultural research centers.

For additional information, contact Sylvia Oliver Inciong, IRRI Information Center, POBox 933, Manila 1099, Philippines; telephone: (62-2) 818-1926 or (63-2) 812-7686 or (63-2) 844-3351 up to 53; fax: (63-2) 8178470 or (63-2) 8811292 or (63-2) 891-1292; e-mail: SINCIONG@CGNET.COM

Recommendation for further reading: *Feeding 4 Billion People. The Challenge for the Rice Research in the 21st Century* **GeoJournal** vol. 35, no. 3 March 1995 pp. 249-388